PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 03



PUNJAB & DELHI ORIGIN

Chole Masala

✦

Spiced Chickpea Curry

The Soul of North Indian Street Food

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Chole Masala

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Chole Masala

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Curry That Built a Street Food Empire

Chole masala's exact origins are hard to pin to a single moment, but its cultural home is unmistakably Punjab and Delhi, where spiced chickpeas have long been paired with fried bread — first kulcha, later the fluffier bhature — to create one of North India's most beloved street food combinations, chole bhature. Old Delhi's Chandni Chowk area, in particular, has been closely associated with the dish for generations, with certain stalls achieving near-legendary status for their version.

The dish's defining spice blend, chole masala, typically includes dried pomegranate seeds (anardana) or dried mango powder (amchur) for tang, along with a warming mix of cumin, coriander, and black cardamom, creating a flavor profile distinctly different from South Indian or other regional chickpea preparations. Many versions also achieve their characteristic dark color from black tea or tea bags simmered directly with the chickpeas, a technique especially associated with the Amritsari style of the dish.

Chole has since traveled well beyond its street-food origins, becoming a staple at Punjabi weddings, a common Sunday lunch dish across North Indian households, and one of the most recognized vegetarian curries on Indian restaurant menus internationally.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Curry That Built a Street Food Empire, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Closely associated with Old Delhi's Chandni Chowk street food culture, where chole bhature stalls have achieved legendary status. A common choice at Punjabi weddings and family celebrations, as well as an everyday household dish. The tea-simmering technique for a dark color is especially associated with Amritsar's distinctive style. Considered one of North India's defining comfort foods, equally at home as street food or a home-cooked Sunday lunch.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	8h + 40m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (strongly recommended for the chickpeas)
- Kadai or wide, heavy-bottomed pan for the gravy
- Small cheesecloth pouch or tea infuser — optional, for the tea bags
- Wooden spoon or spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Chole keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and tastes even better the next day. It freezes very well for up to 3 months, making it an excellent make-ahead dish for batch cooking. Reheat gently with a splash of water to loosen the gravy back to your preferred consistency.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the chickpeas

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Chickpeas (kabuli chana), dried	1½ cups	300 g	1½ katori
Water, for soaking and cooking	as needed	as needed	as needed
Black tea bags — optional, for color	2	2	2
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the masala gravy

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil or ghee	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 large	150 g	1 large
Ginger-garlic paste	1½ tbsp	22 g	1½ chammach
Tomatoes, pureed	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Chole masala powder (or 2 tbsp store-bought)	2 tbsp	12 g	2 tbsp
Kashmiri red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Amchur (dried mango powder)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For garnish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Onion, thinly sliced	½ small	40 g	½ small
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Lemon wedges	4	4	4
Green chili, slit	1–2	1–2	1–2

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Canned chickpeas work well as a time-saver — use two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, and reduce the initial simmering time significantly since they're already cooked. A good store-bought chole masala powder (MDH, Everest, and Shan are reliable, widely exported brands) is a completely acceptable substitute for making the spice blend from scratch. Black tea bags are purely for color and can be omitted entirely without affecting the flavor.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Chickpeas

01 SOAK OVERNIGHT

Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until roughly doubled in size.

02 PRESSURE COOK WITH TEA

Drain and pressure cook the soaked chickpeas with fresh water, salt, and the tea bags (tied in a cheesecloth pouch or tea infuser, if not using bags directly) for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft.



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Cooking the Chickpeas, continued

Chef tip. the tea is purely for color, giving chole its signature dark, restaurant-style appearance — remove the tea bags before proceeding.

03 DRAIN, RESERVING THE LIQUID

Drain the chickpeas, but keep the cooking liquid — it's flavorful and useful for adjusting the gravy's consistency later.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The chickpeas are ready when they mash easily between two fingers with just light pressure, and have taken on a deep brown tint from the tea.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala Gravy

04 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8 minutes.

05 ADD AROMATICS AND SPICES

Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chole masala powder, chili powder, and amchur. Simmer for 10 minutes until the mixture thickens and the oil separates at the edges.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala Gravy, continued

06 ADD THE CHICKPEAS

Add the cooked chickpeas to the gravy, along with some of the reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency. Simmer together for 15–20 minutes, mashing a few chickpeas against the side of the pan to help thicken the gravy naturally.

Texture indicator. chole should be thick enough to cling to the chickpeas, not thin or watery, with a deep brown-red color throughout.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the chole masala powder too early, before the tomatoes have cooked down, can leave the spices tasting raw and dusty. Let the tomato base thicken first, then add the spice blend.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with bhature (fried, fluffy bread) for the classic chole bhature street food combination.
- Garnished generously with sliced raw onion, green chili, and a squeeze of lemon.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with onion rings and a lemon wedge arranged on top, alongside kulcha or naan.

Family Style

- A shared pot at the center of the table with rice, roti, or bhature, and a side of pickled onions.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a hearty topping for rice bowls or alongside a simple green salad for a lighter meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Flavor Right

- The tea-simmering technique is a genuine flavor and color builder, not just a visual trick — don't skip it if you want an authentic dark chole.
- Mashing a few chickpeas into the gravy as it simmers thickens it naturally without needing extra flour or thickeners.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Chole is an excellent make-ahead dish — the flavor genuinely improves after a day in the refrigerator.
- Cook a large batch of chickpeas and freeze in portions, ready to turn into a quick gravy on busy days.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some street vendors add a whole black cardamom and a cinnamon stick directly to the simmering gravy for extra warmth and depth — try this if you want a more complex, restaurant-style flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

260 kcal	11 g	36 g	8 g	10 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Amritsari Chole	an especially dark, tangy version — see our dedicated Amritsari Chole recipe card.
Chole Bhature	chole paired specifically with fried bhature bread, the iconic street food combination.
Punjabi-Style Chole	milder and less tangy, with a heavier emphasis on garam masala warmth.

Can I use canned chickpeas?

Yes — use two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, skipping the soaking and reducing the simmer time significantly since they're already cooked.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my chole pale instead of dark brown?

Likely no tea bags used during cooking, or an under-cooked tomato-onion base. Both contribute significantly to the dish's signature dark color.

Is chole very spicy?

It has warmth from the spice blend but isn't necessarily fiery — adjust the chili powder and green chilies to your preferred heat level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary

GLOSSARY

Chana	Hindi for chickpeas, the base ingredient of this dish.
Amchur	dried mango powder, used for a tangy note in the spice blend.
Anardana	dried pomegranate seeds, sometimes used for tang in chole masala blends.
Bhature	a fluffy, deep-fried leavened bread, the classic accompaniment to chole.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Chole Masala

15m	8h + 40m
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

CHICKPEAS

Chickpeas	300 g
Water	as needed
Black tea bags — optional	2
Salt	6 g

MASALA GRAVY

Oil or ghee	45 ml
Onion	150 g
Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
Tomatoes	200 g
Chole masala powder	12 g
Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
Amchur	3 g
Salt	to taste

FOR GARNISH

Onion	40 g
Fresh coriander	8 g
Lemon wedges	4
Green chili	1–2

METHOD

01 **Soak overnight.** Rinse the dried chickpeas and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until roughly doubled in size.

02 **Pressure cook with tea.** Drain and pressure cook the soaked chickpeas with fresh water, salt, and the tea bags (tied in a cheesecloth pouch or tea infuser, if not using bags directly) for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft.

03 **Drain, reserving the liquid.** Drain the chickpeas, but keep the cooking liquid — it's flavorful and useful for adjusting the gravy's consistency later.

04 **Sauté the onions.** Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and sauté the chopped onion until deeply golden brown, about 8 minutes.

05 **Add aromatics and spices.** Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chole masala powder, chili powder, and amchur.

06 **Add the chickpeas.** Add the cooked chickpeas to the gravy, along with some of the reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Chickpeas	300 g	☐ Black tea bags — optional	2
☐ Salt	see recipe	☐ Oil or ghee	45 ml
☐ Onion	see recipe	☐ Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
☐ Tomatoes	200 g	☐ Chole masala powder	12 g
☐ Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g	☐ Amchur	3 g
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Lemon wedges	4
☐ Green chili	1–2		

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